



From Erving to Goffman

A Work in Performance?

Yves Winkin

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Goffman in the Open Series

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translated by

*Yves Winkin &
Wendy Leeds-Hurwitz*

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EPILOGUE

How (Not) to Complete a Biography?

I summoned my courage at the end of the last session of his course and went to tell Pierre Bourdieu, whose seminar I had been attending since the beginning of the 1975–1976 academic year, that I would be studying at the University of Pennsylvania for the next two years, notably to take Erving Goffman’s courses. He was immediately enthusiastic and suggested that I call Goffman on his behalf as soon as I arrived in Philadelphia. And so, I dared to call Goffman, immediately name dropping my professor. “How is Pierre?” he immediately asked, as if I were an old Bourdieu acquaintance. I soon found myself at his place, summoned to tell him when the French translation of *Frame Analysis* would come out. It was clear Goffman took me for a young colleague of Bourdieu’s rather than his student: A delicate reframing was necessary. But as the months and years went by, Goffman was always charming to me, giving me permission to take his seminar whenever I had the chance and granting me multiple interviews: one about his career, another about my thesis, a third about his differences with Bourdieu on the notion of social class (Winkin, 2022a). All the while, I reported back to Bourdieu about my interactions with Goffman. So it was that, on my return to Europe in 1978, I began contributing short texts to *Actes de la recherche en sciences sociales*, the journal Bourdieu had just founded, and acting as a relay between Paris and Philadelphia.

When I set out in 1982 to collect data on the life of Erving Goffman, I was totally unaware of the field of biographical studies, whether in literature, history, or science. I had published *La Nouvelle Communication* one year earlier. The book included profiles, several pages long, of each member of the “invisible college” whose outline I had traced. I wanted to take a closer look at one of them: Erving Goffman. Several of his works had already been published in translation by Editions de Minuit as part of the series *Le Sens Commun*, edited by Bourdieu. I had in mind the US model of the Viking Portable Library—for example, *The Portable Veblen*, which offered everything a student needs to know about Thorstein Veblen in one compact volume: life, work (with excerpts), bibliography. When Goffman died suddenly in November 1982, I postponed the project I had just started.

A year later, as a Fulbright Scholar at the University of Wisconsin-Parkside, I met Hans Mauksch, who was a visiting professor there. He had known Goffman during his sociology studies at the University of Chicago. I recorded the long conversations we had. And I went to Philadelphia to see Gillian Sankoff, Goffman’s widow and executor, to ask her permission for a more in-depth biographical work than I had initially envisaged. Following on from the interviews with Mauksch, I aimed at collecting testimonies about Goffman at different stages of his life. I also hoped that Sankoff would entrust me with various documents, in particular the manuscript of the unfinished book on casinos. But, while not forbidding me to meet anyone, Sankoff preferred to respect Goffman’s wish that his work should be understood by and for itself. So, she would not tell me anything or give me access to any materials. She would remind me of this agreement in 1986, when I visited her with Bourdieu, who I hoped might persuade her to reverse her decision. I visited her again in 1991 during a very kind, but hopeless, meeting at the Linguistics Department of the University of Pennsylvania, which she was then chairing. Even a request from Goffman’s son Tom didn’t persuade her. Despite our disagreement on this point, we remain on very good terms.

A Letter from Goffman

It was only very recently that I discovered a letter from Goffman which Sankoff probably did not know about, but which reinforces her position. In 1976, the sociologist Irving Horowitz, the founder of the Transaction Publishers publishing house in New Jersey, asked Goffman if he would

agree to a meeting with a young researcher who wanted to embark on a biographical project about him. Goffman replied to his colleague and friend:

I would be willing to send your student a standard c.v., but I guess that's all. If I teach a course this upcoming term, I would be ready to accept anybody you recommended . . . but only if their concern was in the subject matter solely, and not myself. . . . Biography strikes me as a way of reifying something that isn't worth that kind of candle. It is one thing to exploit one's social niche for all the material rewards one can draw from it. Biography strikes me by way of trying to make a virtue of this kind of opportunism, affecting piety where self-respect should dictate chagrin.¹

Goffman's refusal is unequivocal. Had I had the opportunity to read this letter when I was starting my research, I am not sure I would have continued. But the push back I received from Sankoff at the time was not enough to stop me in my tracks. After all, she was not forbidding me from conducting my research; she simply would not help me. So, I started meeting Goffman's colleagues and friends. I also tried to do some fieldwork, visiting all the places that must have been significant for him. And of course, I collected all the documents I could find useful.

Three Methods

In those bygone pre-internet days, I would write a nice letter, usually receive a written reply, and an appointment would be made. I often took advantage of colloquia, teaching opportunities, and research stays in the United States to meet as many people as possible in a short period of time. This is how I collected quite a few interviews in Berkeley in 1987 and in Pennsylvania in 1991 and 1997. Very often, one interview led to another: "You should go and see so-and-so." This is the famous "snowball" method of research. But there were also times when, by sheer chance, I came across a relevant person. Here is an anecdote describing such a case.

In January 1987, I arrived in Berkeley for a semester of teaching, invited by the Sociology Department on the recommendation of Bourdieu. I called around looking for an apartment. I started chatting with a charming woman who asked me what department I would be in. She told me her name was Pearl Terail and that she once knew a sociologist called Erving Goffman. She

¹ Goffman's letter to Horowitz, dated July 2, 1976, is in the Transaction Publishers Archives, HCLA 5676, Special Collections Library, Pennsylvania State University.

explained that she had earned a degree in sociology at Montreal's McGill University in 1937, under the supervision of Everett Hughes (Goffman's patron saint). When we met, she invited a friend of hers, Edith Kasin, who had completed her doctoral studies in human development at the University of Chicago in 1946 and who knew Liz Bott well, Goffman's first great friend. She did not have a current address for Bott, but she asked Ruth Ramsay, another Chicago alumna, who was living in Oslo. Not long after, I received Liz Bott's London address, and in November 1987, I went to see her. The icing on the cake: When I explained to Pearl Terail that Goffman had worked at the Canadian Film Board during the Second World War, she suggested that if I had any film-related questions, I should contact her nephew, William Shatner, better known as Captain Kirk from the legendary *Star Trek* series.

During interviews, I took copious notes and left the recorder running when I was allowed to. Whenever possible, I wrote a long report of the meeting, but I never transcribed the interviews. The tapes have been digitized to ensure their longevity, and I still sometimes listen to parts of them.² But I've always felt that, at my level of "granularity," transcription was unnecessary. On the other hand, I have systematically favored face-to-face meetings, only conducting telephone or video conferencing interviews when necessary.³

My second approach was more akin to participant observation, but it did not exclude gathering valuable information from sometimes unexpected interviews. I spent time (usually a week) in the small town of Dauphin, where Goffman spent his early childhood; in Winnipeg, where he lived for ten years; at the University of Chicago, where he studied; and in Baltasound, on the island of Unst, where he conducted his first fieldwork. I twice visited St. Elizabeths Psychiatric Hospital, the site of his second fieldwork. The only setback was the location of his third fieldwork, the Las Vegas casinos, which have changed so much in recent years that any attempt at historical

² Thanks to Greg Smith, who was able to digitize all the interviews, as well as the photos from *Gender Advertisements*, the originals of which had been given to Pierre Bourdieu by Gillian Sankoff.

³ A researcher at the University of Nevada, Las Vegas, Dmitri Shalin, has opted for the opposite approach: From 2007 to 2017, he conducted numerous telephone interviews with Goffman's relatives and colleagues, which he transcribed verbatim. He then had his interviewees proofread the documents and uploaded them on a site, freely open to consultation, named the Erving Goffman Archives (cdclv.unlv.edu/ega). Shalin has also uploaded numerous documents relating to Goffman. This site has often enabled me to supplement my information or confirm it through cross-referencing. But Shalin's "biocritical hermeneutic" approach is very different from mine, as is his basic position. Because of the moral contract that continues to bind me to Gillian Sankoff and my informants, my archives are totally closed.

identification is impossible. For me, it was a matter of accumulating mental images, rather than photographs, to form a backdrop: the permanent rain on Unst Island, the immense trees in the park of St. Elizabeths Hospital, the patrician atmosphere of Philadelphia's Rittenhouse Square, etc. I kept many diaries, diligently recording my observations every night, as good sociology textbooks dictate. I never assumed that I was seeing and experiencing what Goffman had seen and experienced; that would be too simple and too complex at the same time. Even though he must have been drenched more than twice in Baltasound, nothing would ever give me the means to reconstruct his experience, unless he mentioned the rain in his thesis, which he did not. In fact, my immersions and visits more often underlined an absence in Goffman's work: How is it that Goffman was so detached from his environment? He never mentions the climate on the island of Unst, nor the beauty of the grounds of St. Elizabeths Hospital, and so on. The field remains a laboratory for observing interactions, while the laboratory itself remains unobserved.

Finally, like any social science researcher, I collected and filed documents, whether I sought them out or gathered them at random from encounters and visits. Some treasures have accumulated over the years: a thirty-page letter sent in confidence by friends of Angelica Choate, even though we never met; dozens of photos of Tom Goffman with his mother in Washington, entrusted to me by a colleague of Goffman's without the slightest hesitation. My only regret is that I have not found the photographs Goffman must have taken on the island of Unst with his Leica. But I may yet see them re-emerge one day.

The documents in my file include hundreds of photocopies, now greasy and gray, of articles of all kinds. Sometimes, it is not so much the article as the surrounding advertisements that become historically interesting. In the 1969 issue of *Time Magazine*, for example, where Goffman's first public profile appeared, we discover a coffee advertisement featuring a middle-aged lady in a nightgown and curlers. Behind her, a long corridor with doors on either side. She greets the reader with a slightly embarrassed air. The text simply says: "So Mom has moved across the hallway. Now you'd better think it over . . . have a cup of coffee." It says it all about the independence of young people in the late 1960s, and the inability of parents, still entrenched in their old-fashioned ways, to let them go. It was in this Zeitgeist that Goffman emerged. All the more reason to appreciate his modernity.

From this mass of raw data, I extracted nothing, in the sense that I did not carry out any systematic encoding leading to content analysis by dates, themes, or keywords. I simply read and reread my interview notes and dia-

ries, bookmarked, and highlighted certain passages. In fact, I tried to keep everything in my head and let my brain make the connections, in the manner of gesture specialist Adam Kendon, who explains that he watched his films hundreds of times rather than run them through the computer mill (1979). An eminently fragile procedure, since memory can play tricks on you. But memory can also be astonishingly faithful, allowing us to retrieve a detail from a note twenty or forty years later.

A First Draft

In the summer of 1987, with my head full of my Berkeley interviews, I set about writing the *portable Goffman* for which I'd been contracted by Editions du Seuil—and they wanted to release the book early the following year. Thus, I was faced with a decision. On the one hand, I did not want to fill my head with all the commentaries published in French and English on Goffman and his work, of which there were a few dozen at the time (today there are several hundred); on the other hand, I did not want to let the biographical elements dictate the text: I wanted to “construct” the biography, vigilantly guarding against the false evidence of common sense. Readers of Bourdieu will immediately recognize this paraphrase, inspired by *Le Métier de sociologue*, which was the epistemological bible of a generation of social scientists trained in the 1970s.⁴ In this spirit, I did not want a purely descriptive biography, recounting everything that happened in the hero's life, from year to year, if not day to day, simply because it happened (or rather, because the biographer tracked it down). I was amazed that Richard Ellmann, James Joyce's great biographer, would mention Joyce's visits to the dentist. I was also careful not to be taken in by “influences,” a vaguely causal explanation used to explain everything while explaining nothing. Not because I was against any relationship between a life and a work—otherwise why embark on an intellectual biography? But I refused to draw simple, straightforward connections, as we still too often read and hear, such as “his writing is fluid because he always liked to play in water.” By refusing to enter this logic, I was obviously complicating my task. In addition, in 1986, Bourdieu had published a short text entitled “The Biographical Illusion,” in which he

⁴ The exact phrase is as follows: “The sociologist is never finished with spontaneous sociology, and he must impose on himself an incessant polemic against the blinding obviousness that too cheaply procures the illusion of immediate knowledge and its unsurpassable richness” (Bourdieu et al., 1973, p. 27).

denounced the naiveté of linear biographies using a very powerful image, that of the subway system:

To try to understand a life as a single, self-sufficient series of successive events with no other link than association with a “subject” whose constancy is no more than that of a proper name, is about as absurd as trying to account for a journey on the metro without taking into account the structure of the network, i.e., the matrix of objective relations between the different stations. (p. 71)

This image was often used by those who criticized Bourdieu for his “determinism” (in a word: with Bourdieu, once you are on the tracks, you never change). Personally, this image spoke to me because it illustrated the notion of “trajectory” that Bourdieu defined in his text as “a series of positions successively occupied by the same agent . . . in a space that is itself in the process of becoming” (1986, p. 71). Bourdieu saw these displacements as “placements.” I could see Goffman moving from one university to another. But where Bourdieu’s text became complicated not just to understand but to operationalize was when he proposed moving from an individual biography to a collective one:

In other words, we can only understand a trajectory . . . if we have first constructed the successive states of the field in which it took place, i.e., the set of objective relations that linked the agent in question—at least, in a certain number of relevant states—to all the other agents engaged in the same field and confronted with the same space of possibilities. (1986, p. 72)

This might imply attempting to relate all the members of the doctoral cohort that graduated from the Chicago sociology department in the late 1940s to understand how they positioned themselves in the US academic space from the 1950s to the 1980s, and how just one of them became Goffman, yet that would have been an undertaking beyond what I was willing to attempt. Only Bourdieu himself managed to do so in his *Manet* (2013). I therefore fell back on an approach much more focused on the genesis of the dispositions of Goffman alone, based on a suggestion by Luc Boltanski, who proposed to “go back, in the genesis of the work, upstream of the relatively arbitrary instant when it objectifies itself in writing and even upstream of the time when, through rational apprenticeship to the craft, its author acquires the scientific habitus, in order to access the prior social experiences that are constitutive of the class habitus” (1973, p. 129).

Thus, I concentrated on Goffman's youth and early professional years. The resulting introduction to the book, "Erving Goffman: Portrait du sociologue en jeune homme" ["Erving Goffman: Portrait of the Sociologist as a Young Man"], made a virtue of necessity. The full manuscript had to be completed by September 1987. I was still in the process of presenting Goffman arriving at Berkeley. But according to my interpretative scheme, the essential thing was to set up the intellectual matrix that would enable Goffman to produce ten books in twenty years. That way, I could pick up the pace and present the second half of his life in a few pages. The book came out by the deadline imposed by the publisher (Goffman, 1988).

However, I have never forgiven myself for this sleight of hand. The fact was, I had omitted the second part of the biography. So, I continued to gather data for a complete biography. I continued to reflect on the biographical approach in the history of the social sciences (Winkin, 1999). Above all, I tried to find a middle way between the theoretical position I had adopted from the outset—a biography that resisted "the illusion of immediate knowledge"—and the demands of Bourdieu's program, which were beyond me. I also wanted to maintain a high level of readability, while ensuring a certain narrative fluidity. That is why I took an interest in the concept of the fragment, as it exists in many artistic and literary fields. There is no need for a complete picture; the mind fills in the gaps between the pieces. I had always been struck by the evocative power of the plates in *Balinese Character*, Gregory Bateson and Margaret Mead's great book of several hundred juxtaposed photographs (1942). Sequencing from one photo to the next is effortless, whether in chronological, thematic, or interpretative order. In another register, I was very impressed by François Girard's documentary *Trente-deux films brefs sur Glenn Gould* (1993), which presents the pianist's life and work in segments of one to six minutes (for a total of ninety-eight minutes). That is how I started inserting short vignettes (or "snapshots") into my texts on Goffman. They concentrate a mass of tiny facts, described in the present tense; a freestanding story is set in motion, then fades away as quickly as it appeared. The next story does not necessarily follow chronologically or thematically, but the reader perceives that threads are being tightened, that a web is being woven. I felt like I finally had an appropriate way to render biographical data.

A Second Draft

And so, I (re)launched myself: I asked the University of Liège to suspend my salary for the 1997–1998 school year, and I left with my girlfriend for Philadelphia, determined to finish writing (in English) my biography of Goffman. Thanks to the kindness of Renée Fox, head of the Sociology Department at the University of Pennsylvania, we moved into the house of a colleague on sabbatical. I took all my boxes of documentation with me and began writing again, while actively resuming my interviews with Goffman’s friends, relatives, and colleagues. But a year later, I had to admit that the writing wasn’t finished, and probably was not going to be for a long time. So I asked my colleague and friend Greg Smith, the leading English specialist on Simmel and Goffman, to continue the work with me.

Smith and I went on to write papers together (such as Smith & Winkin, 2012), and we exchanged and shared a lot over the years. We also each produced our own little books on Goffman (Smith, 2006; Winkin & Leeds-Hurwitz, 2013). But we were both caught up in other professional emergencies and made little progress in our joint project for many years. That is, until the day when we both found ourselves retired and, aside from a few projects still underway, plenty of time to ourselves.⁵ It was at this point that I had a strange realization: The writing of Goffman’s biography was beginning to look more and more like Penelope’s web. As I write this, I have to face up to the reality of this undertaking, which will end up lasting as long as the life of its hero: I am already at an age that Goffman never reached; his son Tom, born the same year I was, died a few years ago.

How Not to Complete a Biography

Fortunately, not all biographers suffer from the Penelope syndrome. They complete one (thick) biography and move on to the next. I think with admiration of Pierre Assouline, Benoît Peeters, and François Dosse, for example. But in my almost forty years of circling this Goffman biography, I have come to claim a certain expertise in how to fend off the kiss of death. So, in conclusion, here are my recommendations to all those who would like to embark on the same adventure:

⁵ Greg Smith, together with Michael Hviid Jacobsen, edited the *International Handbook of Goffman Studies*, which was published by Routledge in 2022.

1. Select a (deceased) personality for whom no authorized archive exists.
2. Put an ocean (the Atlantic, for example) between this personality and yourself.
3. Make sure that many of those who knew this personality would prefer either to write this biography themselves, or to invite you to write their biography instead.
4. Let years go by between interviews, until one day you realize that most of your informants will have trouble answering you from beyond the grave.
5. Select a complex interpretative framework that will prove almost impossible to operationalize.
6. But stick with it no matter what, despite the advice of your readers.
7. Spend weeks on minor details, e.g., a date to confirm, a photo to find, a quote to check.
8. Leave your archives in a cheerful mess, to create a romantic atmosphere.
9. Embark on a “meta” study of the status of biography in literary, historical, and scientific studies, so as to “situate” yourself.
10. Regularly embark on various projects, on completely different subjects, in order to clear the table before getting down to business once and for all.
11. Agree to write the same biographical article over and over again (for dictionaries, for example) or small, focused articles in collective works, so that you can get over the urge to go back to the main work.
12. Write in a foreign language that you are familiar with orally, giving you the illusion that you have mastered it as well in writing.

Many more recommendations could be made, but twelve will suffice to get matters started. Or perhaps just a thirteenth, for the magic of the number: When the day comes, do not forget to put your nose in the freshly published work and take a deep breath. The scent will wash away any frustrations.

Thanks

You hold this book in your hand, and I did not fail to smell the first copy that came my way. Thus, I have finally faltered in my own recommendations,

completing a (small) biography of Goffman, focused on a single issue—that of conferences, with a single interpretive framework—that offered by the polysemy of the notion of performance. It's not *the* biography—not yet. But it is getting close.

My thanks go to Michaël Bourgatte, my editor at MkF, for his trust and his exacting standards. Without him, I would still be adding to my list of recommendations. My thanks also go to my three sparring partners in Goffmanology: Wendy Leeds-Hurwitz, Greg Smith, and Rod Watson, who have been with me for decades on this insane quest, never ceasing to encourage me. Lastly, I would like to extend my thanks to Emily Alexander, who painstakingly copyedited the present English-speaking version of the book.